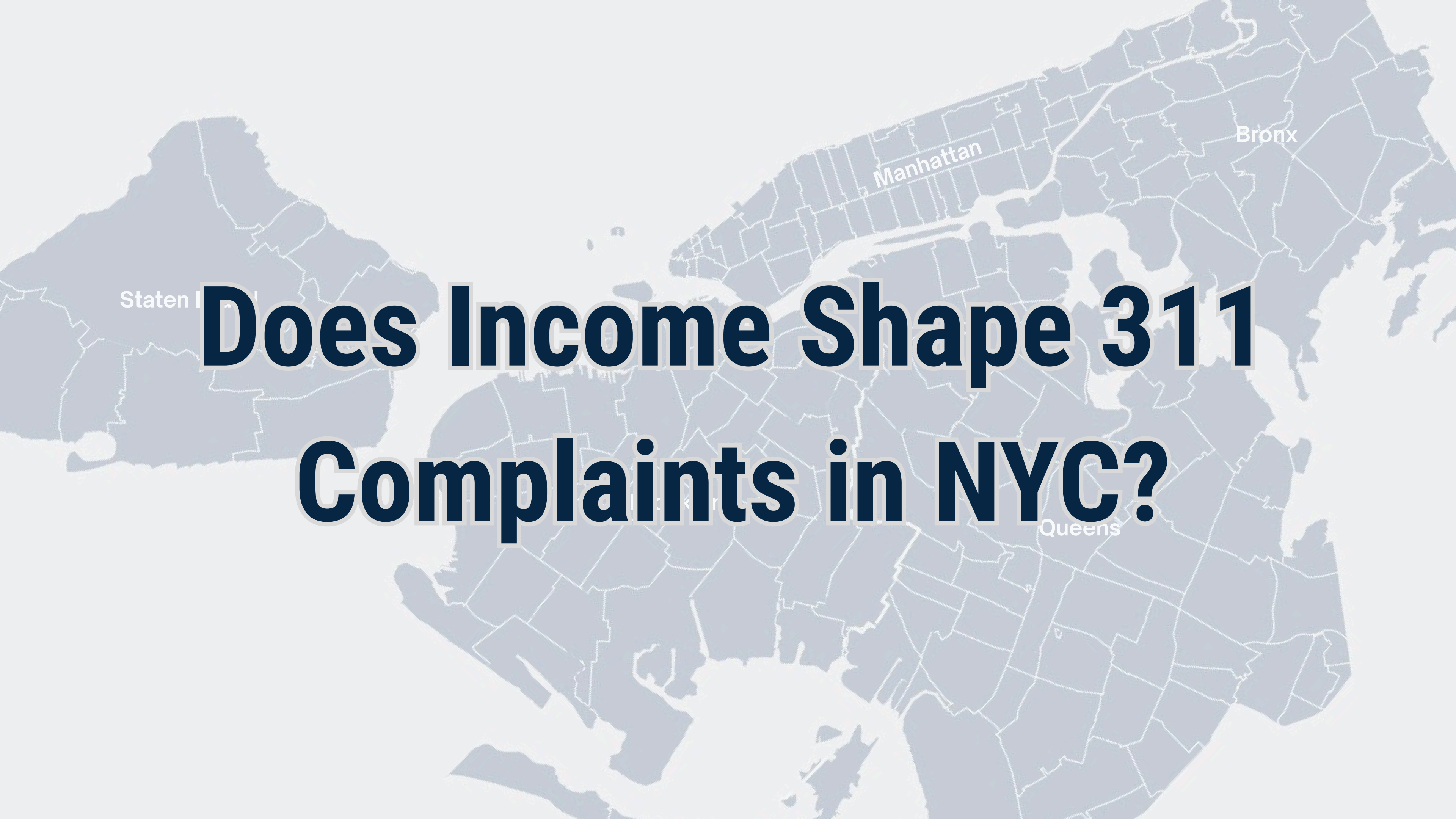
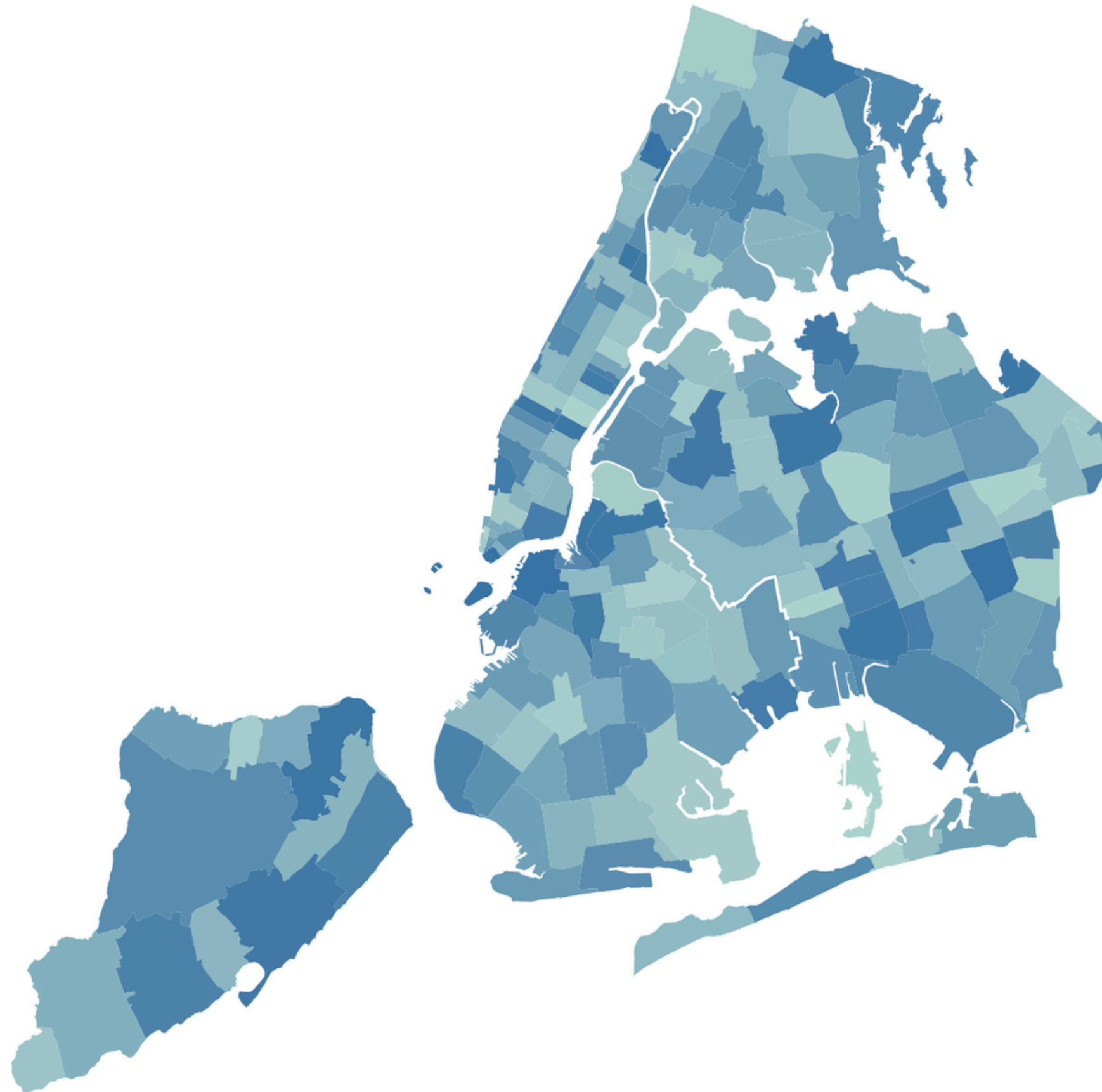




Does Income Shape 311 Complaints in NYC?

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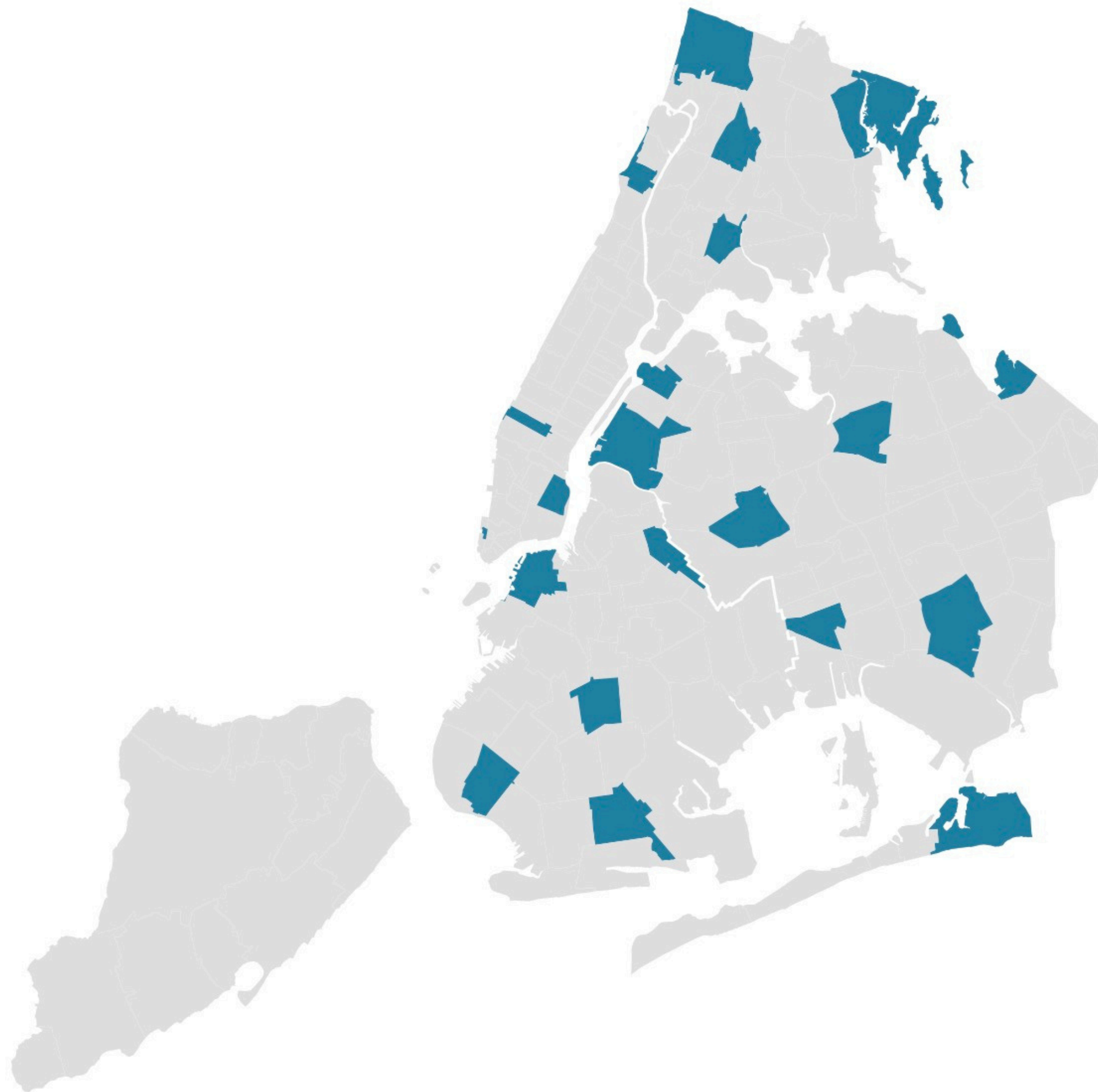
Created with Datawrapper

SCROLLY
NAMA

New Yorkers don't contact 311 at the same rate. Between June 2025 and June 2026, the city averaged **X complaints per 100,000** residents, but complaint rates varied widely across neighborhoods. The top 10% of ZIP codes reported complaints at roughly three times the rate of the bottom 10%. The map is a first look at where New Yorkers report the most problems.

- [NICE TO HAVE] To map primary neighbourhoods to zip codes with github dataset and add hover effect on data wrapper that shows name of neighbourhood + complaints per 100k
- to clean zip codes that don't match datawrapper zip codes

ananya chaba



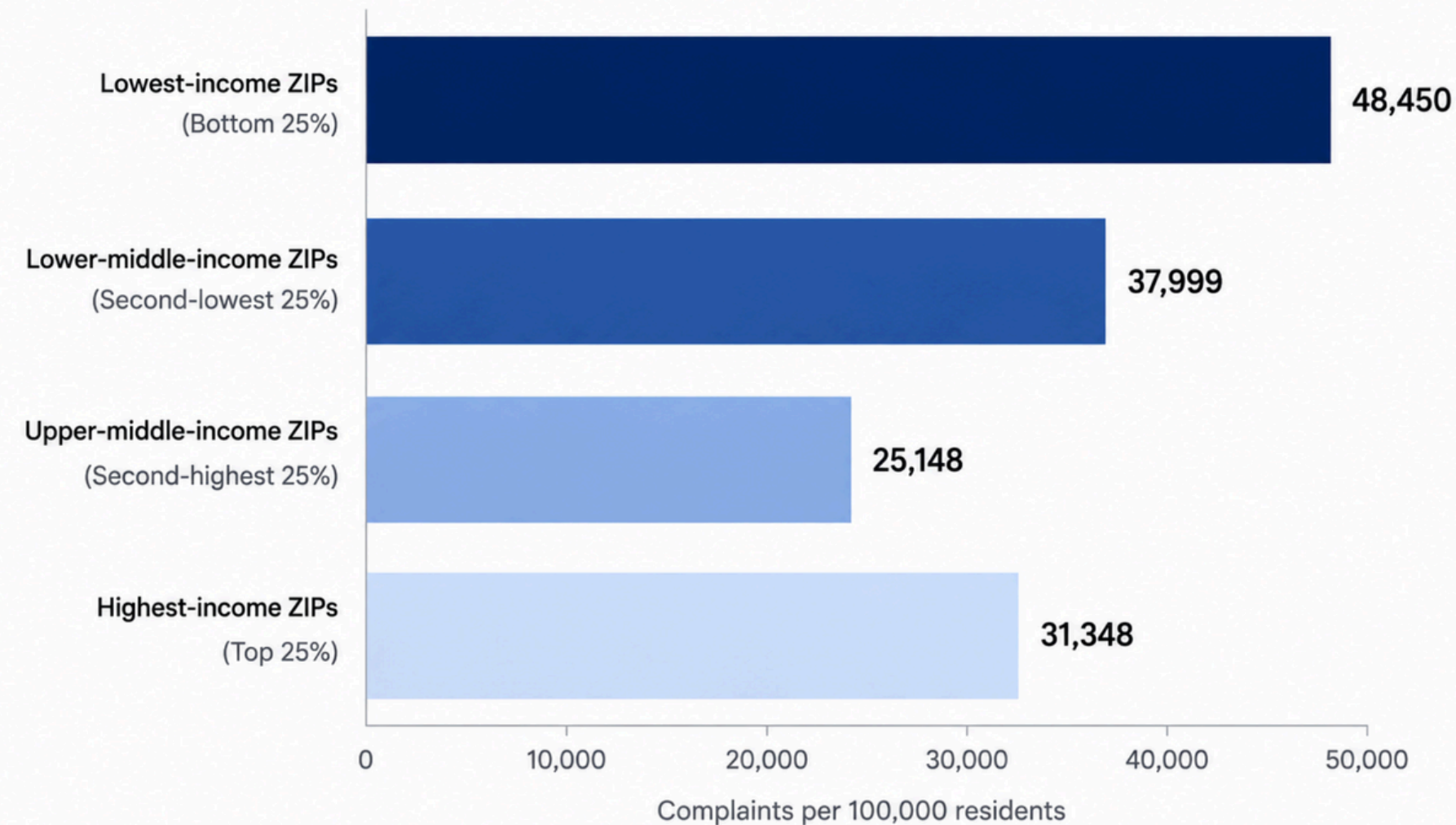
The highest complaint rates are concentrated in just a handful of ZIP codes.

What do these ZIP codes have in common?

- this datawrapper map is made by creating a column on top 10% of complaints v/s all others.

Average complaints per 100,000 residents

By household income group (ZIP codes)



**NORMAL
PAGE**

One explanation for the map is that wealthier New Yorkers may be more likely to use 311—they may have better access to technology, greater awareness of city services, or simply be more accustomed to reporting problems.

To test this, we grouped all NYC ZIP codes into four categories based on median household income and compared the average number of 311 complaints per 100,000 residents.

The pattern was the opposite of what we expected. ZIP codes in the lowest-income quartile reported around 55% more complaints per resident than those in the highest-income quartile.

This does not necessarily mean residents in lower-income neighborhoods complain more. It could also mean these neighborhoods experience more issues that require a 311 report, differences in how residents use the service, or a combination of both. This analysis identifies a pattern, but it cannot determine the reason behind it.

NOTES

VISUAL REFERENCE

Rich Americans enjoy almost 50 percent more greenery in their environment compared with lower-income communities.

Median share of tree canopy coverage, by income



Source: American Forests

Types of Complaints



HEAT / HOT WATER
(e.g., no heat, inadequate heat, hot water issues)



ILLEGAL PARKING
(e.g., blocked hydrants, parking in bike lanes)



NOISE
(e.g., loud music, construction noise)



DIRTY CONDITIONS
(e.g., litter, overflowing trash, dirty streets)



WATER SYSTEM
(e.g., main breaks, leaks, water quality)



STREET CONDITIONS
(e.g., potholes, damaged sidewalks, street repairs)



SNOW OR ICE
(e.g., snow not cleared, ice on sidewalks)



OTHER
(e.g., graffiti, traffic signals, brushes)

Across New York City, the top 311 complaints are about everyday quality-of-life issues.

The most common complaints are HEAT/HOT WATER, ILLEGAL PARKING, and NOISE.

- HEAT/HOT WATER complaints include issues like no heat, inadequate heat, or lack of hot water in buildings.
- ILLEGAL PARKING complaints include vehicles blocking hydrants, bike lanes, crosswalks, or bus stops.
- NOISE complaints range from loud music and parties to construction and street noise.

These complaints reflect the problems New Yorkers experience in their daily lives—and the issues they turn to the city to address.

We also examined whether the types of complaints differ by income. While lower-income neighborhoods report more complaints overall, the kinds of issues people report are largely similar across income groups, with some differences in the most common complaint.

NOTES

VISUAL REFERENCE

inspections and two were in response to a complaint, for 2016 and 2017.

TYPES OF VIOLATIONS



Temperature



Employee-related issue



Pests/bugs



Poor condition of food

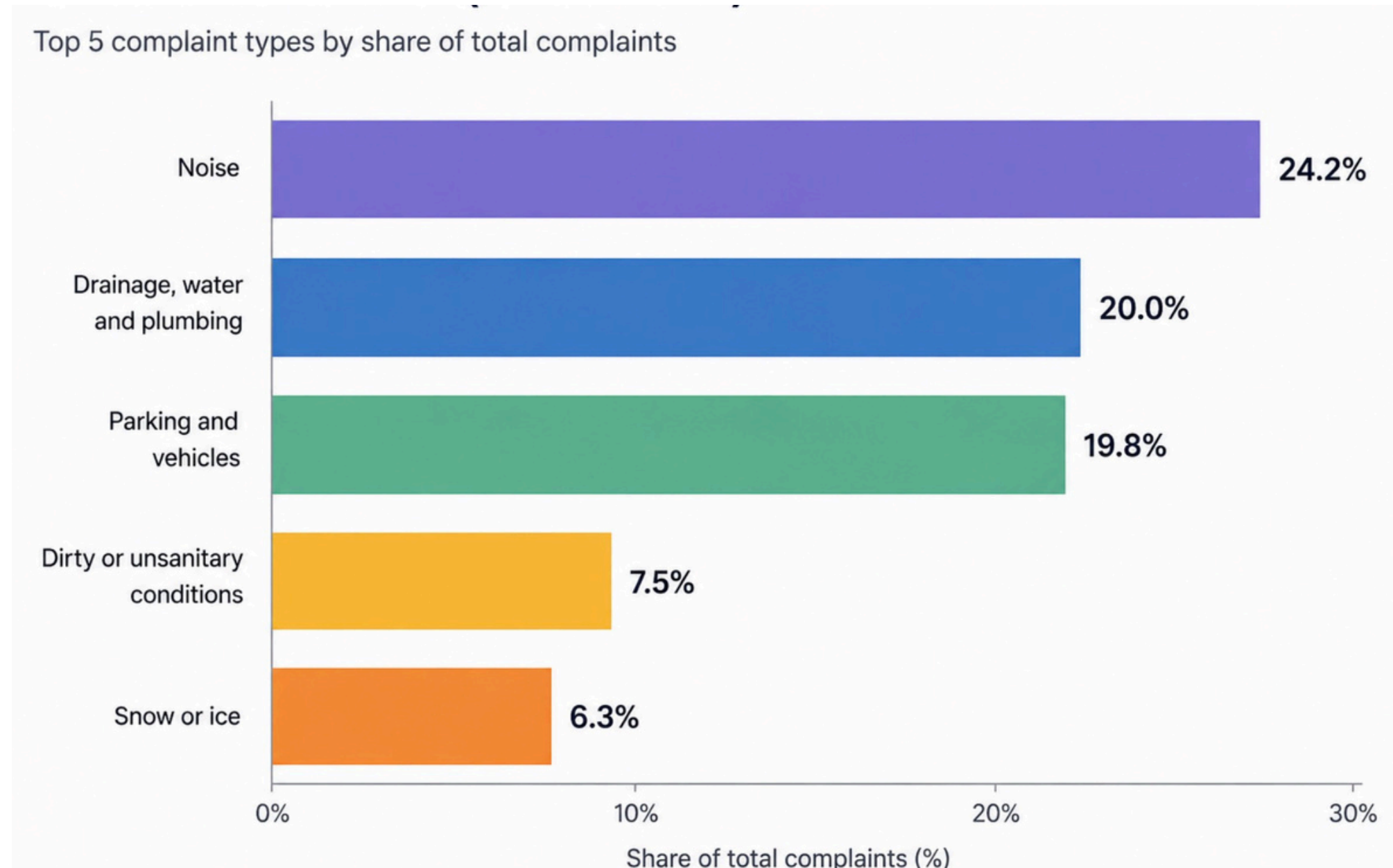


Equipment failure
or problem

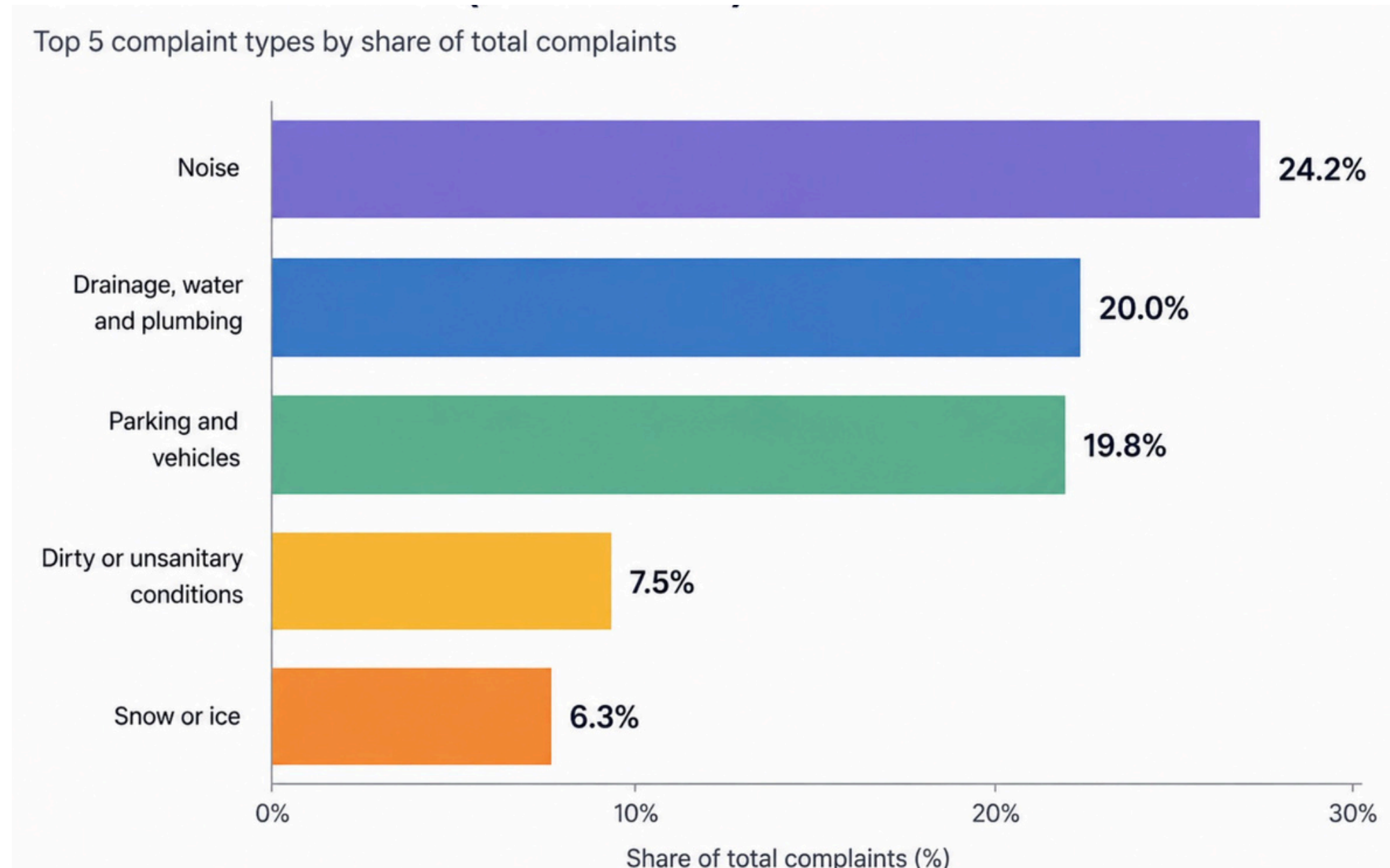


Other

Local health departments typically use a version of the U.S. Food and Drug Administration Food Code, or comparable rules in Canada, to define food-safety violations; however, classifications of the severity of violations can vary among jurisdictions. For example, sometimes the same violation can be high level in one spot but not in another due to how pervasive it is -- a dead roach under a sink could be considered a low-level violation while live cockroaches crawling around popcorn can be a high-level violation. And some jurisdictions might simply designate certain violations as posing more, or less, of a risk to public health.



Residents in lower-income ZIP codes report a larger share of complaints about heat and hot water, plumbing, and dirty conditions. These issues are closely tied to housing quality and essential public services. While lower-income neighborhoods file more 311 complaints overall, these categories also make up a larger share of their complaints.



In the highest-income ZIP codes, complaints are more likely to be about illegal parking, noise, and street conditions than housing-related problems. Heat and plumbing issues still appear frequently, but they account for a much smaller share of complaints than in lower-income neighborhoods.